

22 Prepositions of time

22.1 We use different **prepositions** in different time expressions.



We use **at** with times

at one o'clock	at lunchtime	at night
at the weekend	at the moment	at present
at the end/beginning of ...	at sunset/daybreak	at the same time

We use **on** with specific dates and days.

on 11 February	on Wednesday	on Sunday morning
on the evening of 7 November Compare: in the morning/afternoon/evening at noon/night/midnight		

We use **in** with longer or less specific periods of time.

in May	in 2017	in the 90s
in the 22nd century	in winter	in the past/the future
in a moment (=soon) Compare: at the moment (=now)		

22.2 We can use **in** for a specific period of time in the future.

A: Are you going to Sam's house now?

B: Yes, but I'll be back **in** an hour. (= I'll be back one hour from now.)

We use **in** to say how long something takes.

A: I want to borrow this novel. When can you finish it?

B: I think I can finish it **in** two weeks.

We use **at**, not **on**, with festivals.

Compare: Our cousin Sam usually comes to see us **on** Christmas Day.

The shop will be holding a big sale **at** Christmas.

They had lunch together **on** New Year's Eve.

They handed out many red packets **at** Chinese New Year.



We use **on time** and **in time** in different situations.

The 8 am bus arrived **on** time. (= It arrived at 8 am sharp.)

We got to the terminal **in** time for the 8 am bus. (= We arrived soon enough to catch the bus.)

We do not use a **preposition of time** before words such as *last, next, every, this, today, tomorrow* and *yesterday*.

✓ Let's go see a film this Friday.

✓ We saw a film last Friday.

✗ Let's go see a film on this Friday.

✗ We saw a film on last Friday.

Except: Russians celebrate Mother's Day **on** the last Sunday of November.

22.3 Other prepositions of time include *before, after, during, until, by, upon, from ... to/ until ...*, and *between ... and ...*.

We should wash our hands **before** meals.

Do you want to see a film **after** school?

The school choir had a rehearsal **during** lunchtime.

She is on holiday and will not be back **until** next month.

My boss will be back **by** Wednesday. (= My boss will be back on or before Wednesday.)

Mr Lee will answer your enquiries **on/upon** his return to the office.

Our family lived in Yuen Long **from** 1995 **to** 2001.

The library is open **between** 8 am **and** 10 pm.

The library is open **from** 8 am **to/until** 10 pm.

We can use a verb ending in **-ing** after *before, after, on* or *upon*.

I usually take a shower **before** going to bed.

She put on her slippers **on/upon** entering her flat.

PRACTICE

A Fill in the blanks with **at, on** or **in**. If no **preposition** is needed, write an 'X' in the space.

- 1 Lunar New Year's Day is on 28 January this year.
- 2 We had a picnic on Saturday afternoon.
- 3 They will go to Macau at the weekend.
- 4 Sometimes, Esther cannot sleep at night.
- 5 We often go hiking in spring and autumn.
- 6 Don't go yet. I'll be ready in a minute.
- 7 Peter and I first met in 2008.
- 8 I had a bad dream and woke up in the middle of the night.
- 9 Larry was in Shanghai X last week.
- 10 The pop band arrived in Hong Kong on the afternoon of 25 May.

B Choose and circle the correct **prepositions** to complete the sentences.

- 1 I'm going to Taipei tomorrow. I'll be away ____ the end of the week. until / during
- 2 We set off ____ dawn to go to the train station. at / on
- 3 There will be an open air concert ____ May 12 to June 22. from / between
- 4 The new restaurant will be open for business ____ the end of this month. in / by
- 5 They shouted at each other ____ the meeting. on / during
- 6 Karen offered to help wash the dishes ____ dinner. in / after
- 7 We usually exchange presents ____ Christmas. on / at
- 8 They stayed at my home ____ six days. on / for
- 9 Can you finish this book ____ a week? in / until
- 10 ____ the past, this place was a fishing village. At / In

C Look at Tammy's schedule for the next week and complete the sentences. One has been done for you as an example.

 Sunday	Ken's birthday party (afternoon)	 Thursday	Gym (10 am - 11 am)
 Monday	Job interview	 Friday	Dinner with Sam
 Tuesday	Meet Steve for lunch (1.30 pm)	 Saturday	Call Stephanie about Tim's visit (afternoon)
 Wednesday	Piano lesson (morning) Cinema (afternoon)		Dinner with Linda to discuss plans for summer holidays (evening)

- 1 Tammy is going to Ken's birthday party on Sunday afternoon.
- 2 Tammy has a job interview on Monday.
- 3 Tammy is meeting Steve for lunch at 1.30 in the afternoon on Tuesday/at 1.30 (on) Tuesday afternoon.
- 4 Tammy has a piano lesson on Wednesday morning. On the same day, she will see a film in the afternoon.
- 5 Tammy will be at the gym on Thursday morning. You will find her there from 10 am to 11 am.
- 6 Tammy will have dinner with Sam on Friday.
- 7 Tammy has two things to do on Saturday. First, she will call Stephanie in the afternoon about Tim's visit. Then, she is going to have dinner with Linda in the evening. During/At dinner, they will discuss their plans for the summer holidays.

D Some of the underlined **prepositions** in the conversation are wrong. Write the correct **prepositions** in the spaces provided if necessary. If there is no mistake, put a tick (✓) in the space. If no preposition is needed, write an 'X'.

- Amy Hey Tony, I got a text message from Carol ⁽¹⁾ at yesterday. (1) X
- Tony Oh! What did she say?
- Amy She said she'd be back in Hong Kong ⁽²⁾ on Christmas. (2) at/for
- Tony Cool! How long will she be staying?
- Amy She'll stay for about two weeks.
- Tony Just two weeks? Why not longer?
- Amy She can't. She's going to Taiwan with her family ⁽³⁾ at January. (3) in
- Tony I see. We should fix a date now to meet up then.
- Amy How about ⁽⁴⁾ in New Year's Eve? Why don't we book a table at a cat café so we can go there ⁽⁵⁾ during that afternoon? (4) on
(5) ✓
- Tony I bet she'd love that. She's such a cat lover! Then we can go to Tsim Sha Tsui to watch the fireworks.
- Amy That's a great idea! But can we get there ⁽⁶⁾ at time for the fireworks? (6) in
- Tony Don't worry. We can get there ⁽⁷⁾ by about half an hour. (7) in
- Amy Good, let's do it then. And I'm going to call John ⁽⁸⁾ in this evening to let him know that Carol is coming. (8) X
- Tony But John and I are going to have dinner together later today. I can tell him the news ⁽⁹⁾ since dinner. Do you want to join us? (9) during/at
- Amy No, thanks. I'm going to a dance class in Mong Kok ⁽¹⁰⁾ in three o'clock. (10) at
- Tony Then you'd better leave now. It'll take you about half an hour to get there by MTR, and it's already ⁽¹¹⁾ at half past two. (11) X
- Amy Oh dear, you're right. I need to hurry to get there ⁽¹²⁾ by time. See you later! (12) on

E Complete the website information by filling in the blanks with the correct **prepositions**.

ONE-DAY OUTDOOR PHOTOGRAPHY WORKSHOP

by PhotoPro

Join our workshop and capture nature like a professional!

Hong Kong is a small city, but there are plenty of outdoor photo opportunities if you know where to go. PhotoPro is now offering you the best outdoor photography workshop ⁽¹⁾ in town:



You'll find yourself ⁽²⁾ at/on a beach ⁽³⁾ in Sai Kung ⁽⁴⁾ during the day or under a cliff ⁽⁵⁾ on the island of Ping Chau ⁽⁶⁾ at twilight – we have chosen some of the best places available for you to take photos outdoors.



You'll take some great images – our instructors will be there to help you improve your picture-taking skills.



You'll enjoy taking photos ⁽⁷⁾ in a relaxed environment – just have fun and be creative!

Morning session:

Our morning session starts ⁽⁸⁾ at 9 am and lasts ⁽⁹⁾ until 11 am, allowing you to capture the beauty of nature ⁽¹⁰⁾ under/in the bright morning sun.

Afternoon session:

Our afternoon session starts late, ⁽¹¹⁾ at 4 pm. If you're wondering why – well, nature looks its best ⁽¹²⁾ at sunset. You won't want to miss the chance to capture the best moments of the day, right ⁽¹³⁾ before the sun goes down.

Chief instructor: Cathy Woo

Cathy became a professional photographer ⁽¹⁴⁾ in 2001. She has won more than twenty photographic awards ⁽¹⁵⁾ over/in the past ten years. Her photographs have been published ⁽¹⁶⁾ in a wide range of books and magazines. She is especially interested in outdoor photography. She has travelled to many parts of the world. She has been to many other Asian countries such as Cambodia and Myanmar, and to South American countries such as Peru, capturing countless stunning images of wildlife and natural scenery.

USING THE LANGUAGE

We usually use **at** to refer to precise times, **on** with dates and days, and **in** with longer or less specific periods of time. We also use other **prepositions** to express time. We can use them in, for example, a text message, to specify and remind others of the time of an event. We can also use them to give details about planned activities and their times in a trip, as in the case of an itinerary. Look at the examples below. Note the use of **prepositions of time** in bold.

Text message (excerpt)

When will you be free for dinner **in** June? Emily has to attend tutorial lessons **on** weekdays and I'm going on holiday **at** the end of the month. How about meeting **on** 3 June? We can watch a film **after** dinner.

Itinerary (excerpt)

The half-day tour departs **on** Tuesdays and **at** weekends **at** one o'clock **in** the afternoon. We will first ride on a sampan and explore the traditional lifestyle in Aberdeen Fishing Village. **After** that, we can relax in a seaside cafe or hunt for souvenirs in Stanley Market. **At** sunset we will return to Central.



Your teacher asks you to arrange an itinerary for a Lantau Island day tour to practise using **prepositions of time**. Begin with the given words. Do not write more than 100 words.

Our Lantau Island day tour departs at 9 am daily. **In the morning, we will take the Ngong Ping cable car at Tung Chung. During the ride, we can enjoy a panoramic view of the sea and the mountains. In about 20-25 minutes, we will arrive at Ngong Ping Village and visit the famous Big Buddha. At noon, we will have a vegetarian lunch at the Po Lin Monastery. The highlight of the afternoon will be Tai O fishing village. We can enjoy street snacks or shop for souvenirs in the market. At sunset, we will take a boat trip through the stilt houses. We will return to the hotel before dinnertime.**

(accept any reasonable answer)